

Style Guide

Purpose

A **style guide** ensures consistency, clarity, and professionalism in an organization's written, visual, and design content. Writing technical documents is different from writing marketing content, but both can be consistent in their approach via font, color selections, use of graphics, and uniformity of approach.

Every time I create a document, I am cognizant that almost every company has templates, logos, trade marked elements, and style considerations. Sometimes, however, these assets haven't been considered or fleshed out.

I've created and contributed to a number of style guides over the years, and there are several standards I ensure that my writing meets before anyone can see it.

Lessons Learned

If I've run into an obstacle in a document, I add it to my lessons learned list. One comment that reviewers often say about images is that a window, screen, or application has changed. That happens a lot in IT. To avoid getting bogged down in the weeds, I typically add a note indicating that images are meant to be broad representations.

 All images within this [web page, wiki, document, file, etc.] are sample representations of windows, pages, dashboards, or screens that are likely to be encountered. Minor variations possibly exist.

Considerations

When writing new content, I try to consider:

- Scope
- Audience
- Purpose
- Content Management Process
- Content Publishing
- Content Archiving
- Clarity / Simplicity of Messaging
- Revision & Revision History

- Document Control
- Document Repository
- To ToC or not to ToC? (Table of ... Contents, Tables, Images, Charts)

The following sections are samples I've created for IT groups in the past:

- General Layout
- Lists
- Images

General Layout

Documents

We use 8.5 x 11 size in documents. Using A4 makes the margins, headers, and footers perform sub-optimally. Documents are mostly in portrait orientation. Use landscape for wide tables. You can insert landscaped pages inside a portrait-oriented document.

★ Notes:

- Some clients may opt not to use landscaped pages. Ask the Project Manager to confirm with the client what their preference is.
- Storing documents within Google docs strips formatting such as landscaped pages.

Margins

Use one-inch margins all around. Do not adjust.

Headers & Footers

Headers are .5" from the top margin, and footers are .5" from the bottom margin. Select Different First Page but, leave the first page header empty.



Typical header / footer settings within Word.

Text

Body text for ACME documents is Aptos. Client templates may vary.

Paragraphs are set to no indent and single line spacing with six points above paragraphs and 6 to 8 points below (between paragraphs). Lists (both bulleted and numbered) have three points between paragraphs.

Paragraph ? X

Indents and Spacing Line and Page Breaks

General

Alignment: Left

Outline level: Level 3 ☐ Collapsed by default

Indentation

Left: 0" Right: 0" Special: Hanging By: 0.65"

☐ Mirror indents

Spacing

Before: 6 pt After: 8 pt Line spacing: Single At:

☐ Don't add space between paragraphs of the same style

Word paragraph settings.

- ★ Eliminate manual line returns to ensure consistent pagination and avoid odd spacing situations.

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Lists

Numbered Lists

Do not rely on Microsoft Word's built-in indentation for numbered or bulleted lists. It makes no logical sense. Instead, follow these steps:

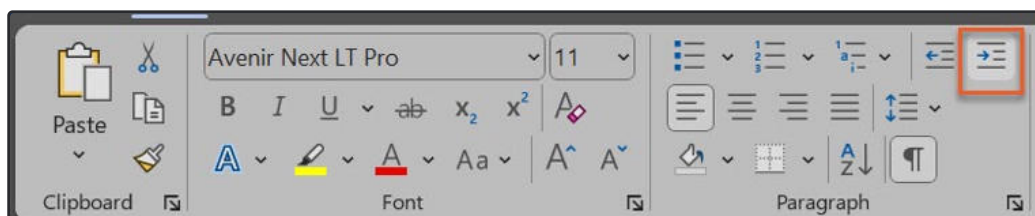
Follow these steps to properly apply numbering to a list in MS Word:

1. Select the sentences you want to number.
2. Set the sentences to **ACME Numbered List Multi-Level Style** tag.
3. If you need to create sub numbers, click the **Increase Indent** icon in the *Paragraph* portion of the menu ribbon.
4. Continue to click the **Increase Indent** icon, as needed, for however many sub-levels of numbering you have.

★ Notes:

Word has:

- Nine levels in its multi-level styles by default.
- A tendency to be helpful: With numbered lists, Word sometimes starts from the previous list.
- You can right-click a numbered line and select **Restart at 1** from the context menu.



Bulleted Lists

❌ Do not use bullets for steps. Steps should be numbered.

Bulleted lists often have a hierarchy, so we created a multi-level bulleted style within our template.

Apply the ACME Multi-level Bulleted List style to items that need to be bulleted. Use Word's indent tool to indent lines to the appropriate level as seen in the example below.

- Level 1
 - Level 2
 - ⊙ Level 3
 - Level 4
 - Level 5
 - ▣ Level 6
 - ◆ Level 7
 - ◇ Level 8
 - ◊ Level 9

Should you need it, we have defined nine levels of indented bullets.

Images

All images need to be in the highest available resolution so that they do not appear fuzzy or pixelated in the document or within a PDF of the document. However, they cannot be such high-resolution that the file is incredibly large.

If you use images, include this generic note so that we don't have to make updates for minor screen changes.

★ **Note:**

All images are example representations of windows, pages, and screens that the technician is likely to encounter. Minor variations possibly exist.

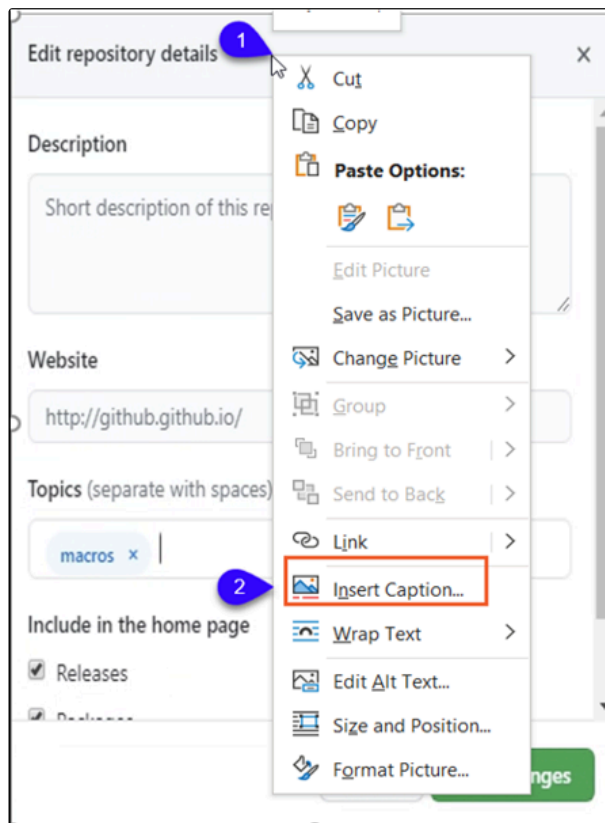
Do not include circles, boxes, arrows, call-outs, or numbers in your images. The editor will do that so that images are consistent across all documents.

Save images as .PNG, which is a lossless format. When you save as a .JPG, the image is lossy (image metadata gets discarded) and appears pixelated within the document.

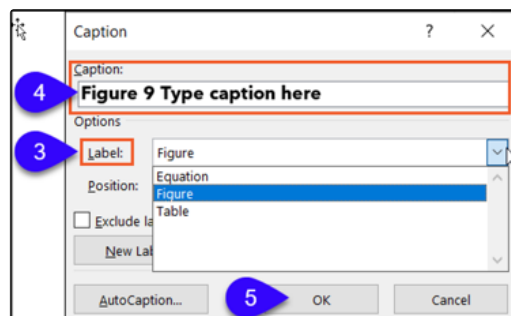
Include drawings, figures, tables, and screen shots, whenever it seems useful. Give each graphic element an informative caption that explains why this image is important. Keep in mind that the editor is not a cloud architect, so describe an architectural or process-related drawing so that a non-technical person gets a general idea of what the image is conveying.

Follow these steps to include a caption that can then be included in a Table of Figures:

1. Right click the image so the context menu appears.
2. Click **Insert Caption**. The *Caption* window appears.
3. Ensure that the **Label** is set to Figure.
4. Place your cursor in the **Caption** field, enter a space, and type your caption.
5. Click OK. The **Caption** style has already been set in the template. The caption appears below the image. Word automatically numbers images.



Inserting a caption.



Label your caption.

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